

BYLINE

Correspondent & Contributor Portal

Product Brief — Version 1.0

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Product Name	Byline
Document Version	1.0
Date	July 2026
Product Owner	Digital — KBC
Companion Tool	Lineup (Editorial Content Calendar)
Tech Stack	React JS Firebase Vercel
Methodology	Agile — 2-week sprints
Status	Approved for Development

1. Context & Problem Statement

KBC operates a network of correspondents and freelance contributors who report from the field — covering counties, beats, and stories that the central newsroom cannot staff permanently. These contributors file stories in text, audio, video, and images, and are paid based on what is used across KBC's platforms.

Currently there is no formal system managing this relationship. Story commissions happen informally, filing is done via email or WhatsApp, proof of broadcast is undocumented, and payment is processed through manual paperwork that is easy to dispute and slow to process. This creates three chronic problems:

- Correspondents have no visibility into whether their stories aired or were published
- Finance has no reliable record of what was commissioned, used, and at what rate
- Editorial has no audit trail of what was assigned, filed, and approved

Byline solves all three problems by giving correspondents, editors, and finance a single shared system for the full lifecycle — from assignment through filing, editorial approval, proof of use, and payment.

2. Product Vision

Byline is KBC's internal correspondent management portal. It is the system of record for everything that happens between assigning a story to a contributor and paying them for it.

In its first version, Byline will be operated internally — editors register correspondents, assign stories, and manage the workflow. In future versions, correspondents will be able to self-register and move through the full onboarding process without human intervention.

Byline is a companion to Lineup, KBC's editorial content calendar. They are separate tools today, but they share data — events planned in Lineup can generate assignments in Byline. Integration will be scoped in a future version.

3. The Byline Workflow — End to End

This is the full workflow Byline manages. Every stage maps to a feature the system must support.

#	Stage	What Happens	Who Acts
1	Registration	Editor registers a new correspondent internally — name, contact, ID, bank details, specialisation. Account is created and credentials sent to the correspondent.	Editor / Super Admin
2	Assignment	Editor creates a story assignment on the portal — headline, brief, platform target, deadline — and assigns it to a specific correspondent. Correspondent receives a notification.	Editor

3	Field Reporting	Correspondent goes to the field and gathers material.	Correspondent
4	Story Submission	Correspondent logs into the portal and submits their filing — text, audio, video, images, or any combination. Submission is timestamped and logged.	Correspondent
5	Editorial Review	Assigned editor reviews the submission. They can approve it, request revisions, or decline it. Status is updated on the portal and the correspondent is notified.	Editor
6	Publication / Airing	The story is used on one or more KBC platforms — TV, Radio, Website, Social Media. The editor marks the story as Published/Aired on the portal and records which platform(s) it appeared on.	Editor
7	Proof of Use	Correspondent attaches evidence of publication — a website URL, YouTube link, or audio clip of the radio broadcast — next to their original submission. The editor confirms the evidence is valid.	Correspondent + Editor
8	Payment Calculation	The system automatically calculates the payment due based on the platform(s) the story aired on, using the active rate card set by the Managing Editor.	System (auto)
9	Invoice Generation	At end of month, the correspondent generates a Stories Report from the portal. The report lists all filings, platforms, rates, and total amount due. It is auto-generated and can be downloaded as a PDF payment request.	Correspondent
10	Payment Processing	The correspondent submits the downloaded report to Finance. Finance processes the payment. Once paid, the correspondent marks the claim as Paid on the portal. Unpaid claims remain visible as Pending.	Correspondent + Finance

4. Users & Roles

Role	Who	Permissions
Super Admin	Head of Digital / Digital Manager	Full access: manage users, manage rate card, view all correspondents, all assignments, all payment records, all reports
Managing Editor	Managing Editor / Editorial Leadership	Set and update the rate card. View all assignments and payment summaries. Confirm stories as Published/Aired.
Editor	Desk Editors, Producers	Register correspondents, create assignments, review submissions, approve or request revisions, mark stories as Published/Aired, confirm proof of use
Correspondent	Freelance reporters, field contributors	View own assignments, submit filings, attach proof of use, generate monthly stories report, track payment status

5. User Stories — Version 1

These are the stories that must be delivered in V1. Nothing outside this list is in scope.

ID	As a...	I want to...	So that...
US-01	Super Admin	log in securely and access the full system	I have oversight of all correspondents and activity
US-02	Super Admin	manage the rate card — set rates per platform and update them	payment calculations always reflect current editorial policy
US-03	Editor	register a new correspondent with their personal, contact, and bank details	they are in the system and ready to receive assignments
US-04	Editor	create a story assignment with a title, brief, target platform, and deadline, and assign it to a correspondent	the correspondent knows exactly what is expected and when
US-05	Correspondent	log in and see all assignments sent to me	I know what I have been asked to cover
US-06	Correspondent	submit my filing in text, audio, video, or images — or a combination	my work is on record with a timestamp
US-07	Editor	review a submission and mark it as Approved, Revision Needed, or Declined	correspondents know the status of their work
US-08	Editor	mark a story as Published/Aired and record which platform(s) it appeared on	there is an official record of use that triggers payment eligibility
US-09	Correspondent	attach proof of use — a URL, YouTube link, or audio clip — to my submission	I have documented evidence that my work was used

US-10	Editor	confirm or reject a correspondent's proof of use	only verified evidence triggers payment calculation
US-11	Correspondent	see the payment amount calculated automatically for each approved and verified story	I know what I am owed before I generate my report
US-12	Correspondent	generate a monthly Stories Report as a downloadable PDF showing all filings, platforms, rates, and total amount due	I have a formal document to submit to Finance
US-13	Correspondent	mark a payment claim as Paid once Finance has processed it	my payment history is accurate and up to date
US-14	Correspondent	see all Pending claims clearly on my dashboard	I can follow up on outstanding payments
US-15	All Users	use the application comfortably on a mobile phone	I can file, review, and check status from anywhere

6. Rate Card — System Design

The rate card is the engine that drives automatic payment calculation. It must be managed inside the system by the Managing Editor or Super Admin — not hardcoded by developers. When a story is confirmed as used on a platform, the system looks up the active rate for that platform and applies it.

The table below shows how the rate card should be structured. Actual amounts are set by the Managing Editor.

Content Type / Platform	Base Rate (KES)	Editable by	Notes
TV Package (National)	Set by Managing Editor	Managing Editor / Super Admin	Applies when story airs on KBC TV national broadcast
TV Package (Regional / Vernacular)	Set by Managing Editor	Managing Editor / Super Admin	May differ from national rate
Radio Clip (National)	Set by Managing Editor	Managing Editor / Super Admin	Applies when audio airs on national radio
Radio Clip (Vernacular Station)	Set by Managing Editor	Managing Editor / Super Admin	Applies per vernacular station — can vary
Website Article	Set by Managing Editor	Managing Editor / Super Admin	Applies when story published on kbc.co.ke
Social Media Post	Set by Managing Editor	Managing Editor / Super Admin	Applies when story used as social content
Multi-platform (same story)	Set by Managing Editor	Managing Editor / Super Admin	System sums rates per platform used

Important: If a single story airs on both TV and Radio, the system should calculate and sum both rates automatically. The correspondent's report will show the breakdown per platform.

7. Version 1 — Scope Definition

7.1 In Scope — Must Ship in V1

- User authentication via Firebase Auth (email/password)
- Four user roles: Super Admin, Managing Editor, Editor, Correspondent
- Correspondent registration by Editor (internal — no self-registration yet)
- Story assignment creation and dispatch to correspondent
- Multi-format story submission: text, audio, video, images
- Editorial review workflow: Approved / Revision Needed / Declined
- Platform confirmation by Editor: TV, Radio, Website, Social Media
- Proof of use submission by Correspondent: URL, YouTube link, audio clip
- Editor confirmation of proof of use
- Rate card management interface for Managing Editor / Super Admin
- Automatic payment calculation based on platform and active rate card

- Monthly Stories Report — auto-generated PDF with full filing breakdown
- Payment status tracking: Pending / Paid
- Finance email notification when a payment request is lodged
- Mobile-responsive design
- Firebase Firestore database, Firebase Auth, Firebase Storage for file uploads
- Deployed on Vercel

7.2 Out of Scope for V1 — Backlog

- Correspondent self-registration and onboarding
- Integration with Lineup editorial calendar
- Automated proof of use verification
- Finance system integration or direct payment processing
- Analytics dashboard for editorial or finance leadership
- Contract or accreditation document management
- Multi-language support

8. Sprint Plan

Byline is more complex than Lineup. A realistic V1 delivery is 4 sprints of one week each — approximately 4 weeks from kickoff.

Sprint	Dates	Deliverables	Goal
Sprint 0 Days 1–2	Week 1 Days 1–2	Repo setup, Firebase project (Auth + Firestore + Storage), Vercel pipeline, folder structure agreed, auth scaffolding	Working skeleton: you can log in with a role
Sprint 1 Week 1	Week 1	Correspondent registration flow, Editor dashboard, assignment creation and dispatch, Correspondent dashboard showing assignments	Editors can register correspondents and assign stories
Sprint 2 Week 2	Week 2	Multi-format story submission (text + file uploads to Firebase Storage), editorial review workflow, status notifications	Correspondents can file; editors can review and approve
Sprint 3 Week 3	Week 3	Platform confirmation, proof of use submission and editor confirmation, rate card management interface, automatic payment calculation	Payment calculation is live and accurate
Sprint 4 Week 4	Week 4	Monthly Stories Report PDF generation, payment status tracking, Finance email notification, mobile QA, final testing	V1 complete — full workflow from assignment to payment request

9. Product Backlog — V2 & Beyond

Feature	Version	Priority	Notes
Correspondent self-registration portal	V2	High	Full onboarding without human intervention
ID verification and accreditation document upload	V2	High	Media Council of Kenya compliance
Contributor agreement / contract e-signature	V2	High	Formal legal record of engagement terms
Integration with Lineup — assignments from calendar events	V2	High	Plan in Lineup, assign in Byline
In-app notifications (not just email)	V2	Medium	Real-time status updates for correspondents
Editor analytics — filings per correspondent, approval rate	V2	Medium	Editorial performance visibility
Finance dashboard — total payables per month, per correspondent	V2	Medium	Finance planning and reconciliation
Automated proof of use — scrape KBC website / YouTube	V3	Medium	Reduce manual verification burden
Direct integration with KBC Finance / ERP system	V3	Low	Eliminate manual payment request handoff
Multi-language portal (Kiswahili)	V3	Low	Accessibility for vernacular correspondents
Correspondent performance rating by editors	V3	Low	Quality tracking over time

10. Technical Notes for Developers

Layer	Choice	Note
Frontend	React JS	Same stack as Lineup — consistent codebase
Auth	Firebase Authentication	Email/password. Custom claims for role management — same pattern as Lineup
Database	Firebase Firestore	Structured collections: users, correspondents, assignments, submissions, rates
File Storage	Firebase Storage	For audio, video, image uploads from correspondents in the field
PDF Generation	jsPDF or React-PDF	Monthly Stories Report must be a clean, downloadable PDF
Email Alerts	Firebase Extensions (Trigger Email)	Finance notification on payment request lodge. Use Mailgun or SendGrid
Hosting	Vercel	Same deployment pipeline as Lineup

Note on Firebase Storage security rules: file uploads must be restricted so correspondents can only read and write their own files. Do not leave Storage in open test mode for production.

11. Definition of Done — V1

V1 is ready to ship when ALL of the following are true:

- All 15 user stories in Section 5 are implemented and testable
- An editor can register a correspondent, create an assignment, and review a submission end-to-end
- A correspondent can log in, view assignments, submit a filing with file attachments, attach proof of use, generate a PDF Stories Report, and track payment status
- The rate card can be updated by the Managing Editor without developer involvement
- The PDF Stories Report is accurate, professional, and downloadable
- Finance receives an email when a payment request is lodged
- The application works on a standard Android mobile browser
- The Product Owner has reviewed the live build and signed off

12. Relationship to Lineup

Byline and Lineup are separate applications with a planned future integration. The relationship is:

Lineup — Editorial Calendar	Byline — Contributor Portal
Plans content around events and key dates	Manages the people who create that content
Internal editorial teams: editors, reporters, producers	External contributors: correspondents, freelancers
Tracks content from Planned to Published	Tracks contributors from Assignment to Payment
No payment workflow	Full payment lifecycle built in

In V2, an event created in Lineup will be able to generate a story assignment in Byline with one action — closing the loop between editorial planning and contributor management.